INITIATIVE (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Initiative determines turn order during combat. At the start of an encounter, every participating creature makes an **Initiative roll**, a **Dexterity** check. The roll gives an **Initiative count**, which sets its place in turn order. The order stays fixed for the whole combat.

🎲 Calculating your Initiative bonus:

Initiative bonus = Dexterity modifier + miscellaneous bonuses (feats, spells, items, etc.). Some classes and feats change this roll.

- **Class**: Barbarian level 7 – **Feral Instinct**: Advantage on Initiative rolls.
- **Feat**: **Alert**: add your Proficiency Bonus to Initiative. You can also swap Initiative with a willing ally.

Choosing the Initiative rule:

- **Standard rule** (default): each player rolls 1d20 + Initiative bonus. The DM rolls for monsters. One roll for a group of identical monsters. Table rule
- **Table option (fixed score)**: the DM uses a fixed score of 10 + Initiative bonus, +5 with Advantage and −5 with Disadvantage. Table rule

Ties:

- Between monsters, the DM decides who goes first.
- Between player characters, they decide among themselves.
- In a monster / PC tie, the DM decides.

Table tip: on a tie, reroll 1d20 among those involved. The highest wins. Table rule

Special case:

Note in advance how your mount, familiars, or summons work for Initiative, to save time at the roll.

🐴 Controlling a mount:

You can control a mount only if it has been **trained to bear a rider** (horse, mule...). While you ride it, it acts on **your Initiative** and can take only the **Dash**, **Disengage**, or **Dodge** actions. It can move and act on the turn you mount it. An **independent** mount (it lets you ride but doesn't obey) keeps its own Initiative and acts on its own.

Step 1 – Establish positions:

The DM describes the starting positions of characters and enemies based on their declarations (marching order, stealth, placement on a map, etc.).

Step 2 – Determine surprise:

In 2024, surprise gives **Disadvantage** on the surprised creature's Initiative roll.

Example: an ambushing group attacks unseen. The unaware enemies roll Initiative with Disadvantage.

- **Change from 2014**: a surprised creature no longer loses its first turn. It only suffers Disadvantage on Initiative.
- Being **Incapacitated** when you roll Initiative also gives Disadvantage.
- If you are **Invisible** when you roll Initiative, you have **Advantage**.

Step 3 – Roll Initiative:

- **Normal**: 1d20 + Initiative bonus.
- **With Advantage**: 2d20 + Initiative bonus, keep the higher.
- **With Disadvantage**: 2d20 + Initiative bonus, keep the lower.
- Advantage and Disadvantage cancel: a single d20.

Example: an Elf (Dex +3) is surprised. He rolls 2d20 + 3 and keeps the lower. With 14 and 6, his Initiative is 6 + 3 = 9.

Step 4 – Take turns:

Once the order is set, each creature acts on its turn. When all have acted, a new round begins, until combat ends.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

Even at Disadvantage, a character can roll a better Initiative than another with Advantage: Initiative remains a d20 roll with wide swings. It can feel inconsistent, especially if a surprised character acts before their attackers.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe a reflexive jolt from the surprised character (acting on instinct, without clarity), or stress the clumsiness of the one springing the surprise.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Readying an action

You can't delay your turn: you act or you ready an action. A readied action isn't a commitment: you can drop it for an Opportunity Attack, but you have only one Reaction per round.

Readying a spell

A readied spell spends its slot when readied, even if the trigger never happens. The target must be in range when the trigger occurs, and the action happens right after it.

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